

Class 11: Social Movements online, in effect, dying out, and going forward

Online

Dr. Michael C. Zeller

Agenda for the day

- Opening notes
- Theses from an earlier age of the internet (Diani 2000)
- Poll: Movements online
- Movements changed by the Internet
- Online replacing offline activism
- Any questions, concerns, feedback for this class?

Opening notes



- short synopsis for final essay due Friday (17 January) (send to me via email)

Presentations line-up

Date	Presenters	Method
4 Dec:	Daichi, Seongyeon, Jehyun	ethnography
8 Jan:	Ayla, Tara, Theresa, Annabelle	discourse analysis
15 Jan:	Luna, Emilene, Raffa, Sofia	TBD

Theses from an earlier age of the internet (Diani 2000)

- 'computer mediated communication' (CMC)
- types of communication
- features of internet tools
- different organisation types and CMC



‘computer mediated communication’, CMC:

- interpersonal communication through the use of computers or digital devices, now typically involving internet channels
 - **then**: (mass) email, message boards, instant messaging
 - **now**: social media, encrypted messaging with different message types (photo, video, audio), AI-generated material, **other ways??**
- sometimes **easing** how people communicate; sometimes **changing** it

Diani (2000) - types of communication

Private

Public

Direct

- face-to-face between activists
- message restricted to group boundaries

- in public spaces (e.g., demos)
- communicating to person(s) (e.g., speeches, leafleting)
- may overlap with attempts to attract media attention (i.e. 'public mediated')

Mediated

- messages within group boundaries but transmitted through tech
- (e.g., email, phone calls) with varying privacy

- all media-related communication (e.g., press releases, adverts, 'manipulation of media through spectacular events')

Features and facets of internet tools

Diani (2000) - organisations and communication

some hypotheses about CMC and different movement organisations

Organisation type	Importance of CMC	Effects?
Orgs. focusing on professional resources	high	CMC supports professionalised groups that sometimes require large mobilisation (e.g., Greenpeace), helping to 'get the word out'
Orgs. mobilising participatory resources	moderate/low	CMC reinforces already existing ties; these orgs. remain reliant on direct, face-to-face interactions to recruit, build collective identity, and maintain commitment
Orgs. mobilising participatory resources	moderate/low	"Sustained collective action is unlikely to originate from purely virtual ties if they are not sustained by previous interaction"
Transnational networks	moderate	CMC helps link (especially former) activists and militants (individuals and groups) to promote shared

Diani (2000) - theses of an earlier internet age

Broadly, internet tools ('computer mediated communication', **CMC**) allow...

- greater speed (and accuracy) of communication
- less cost of communication
- greater connectivity across distances
 - unifying different national or regional parts of a movement

Are these assertions still 'as true' as they were in 2000?

Diani (2000) - theses of an earlier internet age

Can CMC create new types of communities (if so, what kinds)? Can they create collective identity and enable **durable/sustained** activism?

- can that happen with online anonymity?

most examples of personal interaction in electronic discussion groups actually miss some of the requirements usually associated with the idea of community. Participants in those lists often hide their personal identity, participate occasionally, are not tied in any sort of committed relationship and **are mostly involved in dyadic or at most triadic interactions**

Poll: Movements online

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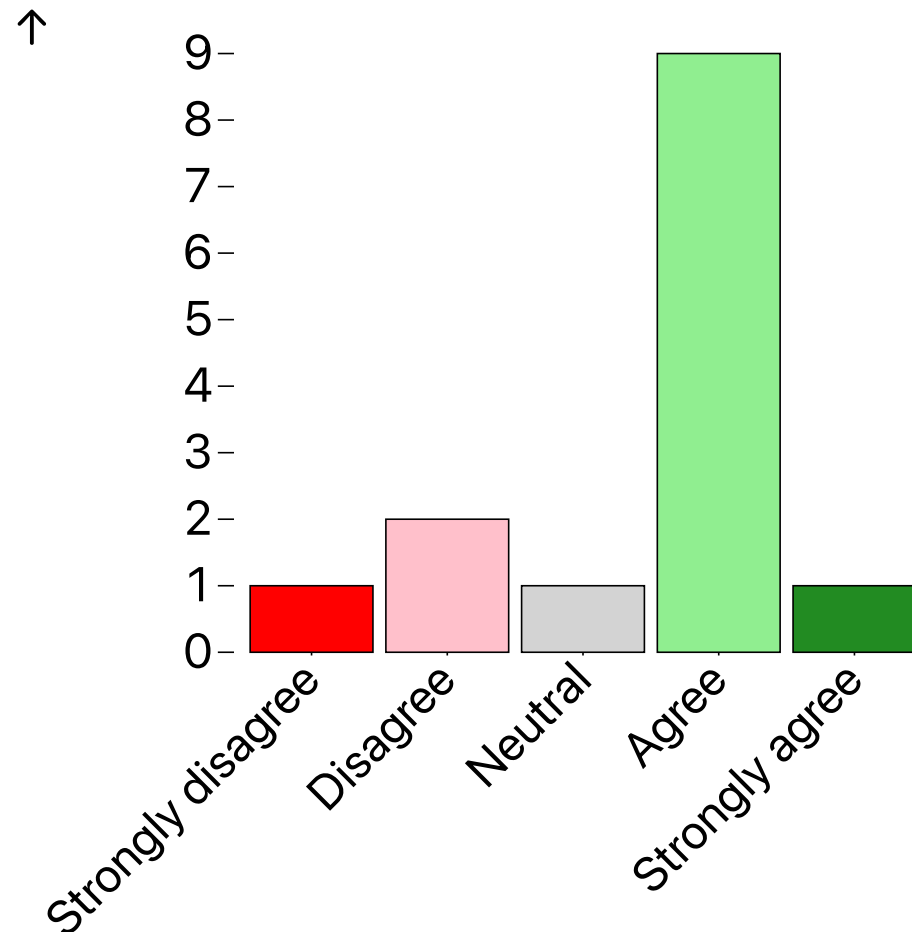
Take the survey at

<https://forms.gle/xwWefHu7eDA>

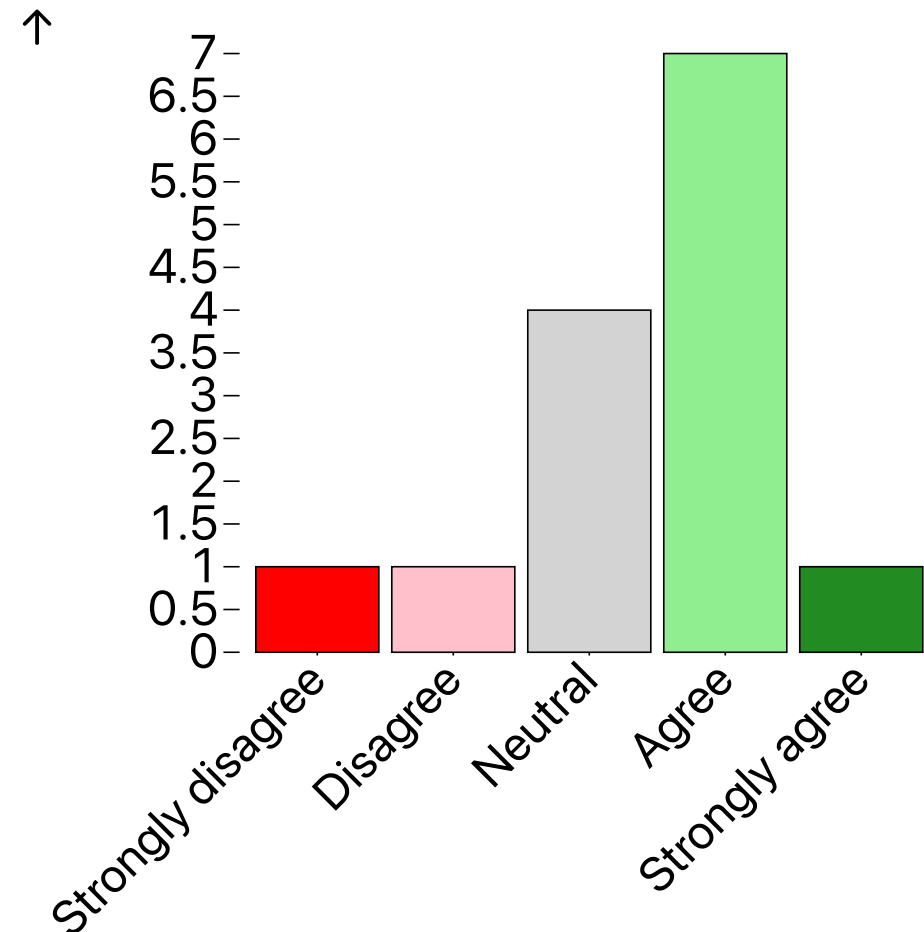
- most important online tool for SMs?
 - online organising more democratic?
 - online movements more individualised?
 - platforms amplify movements of the marginalised?
-
- platforms not so useful since algorithms favour sensationalism?
 - online movement activity often encourages a “slacktivism”
 - movements online face greater censorship and surveillance?
 - should online platforms be more regulated to prevent movements (and other actors) from spreading misinformation?

Poll results (Respondents: 15)

online organising more
democratic?

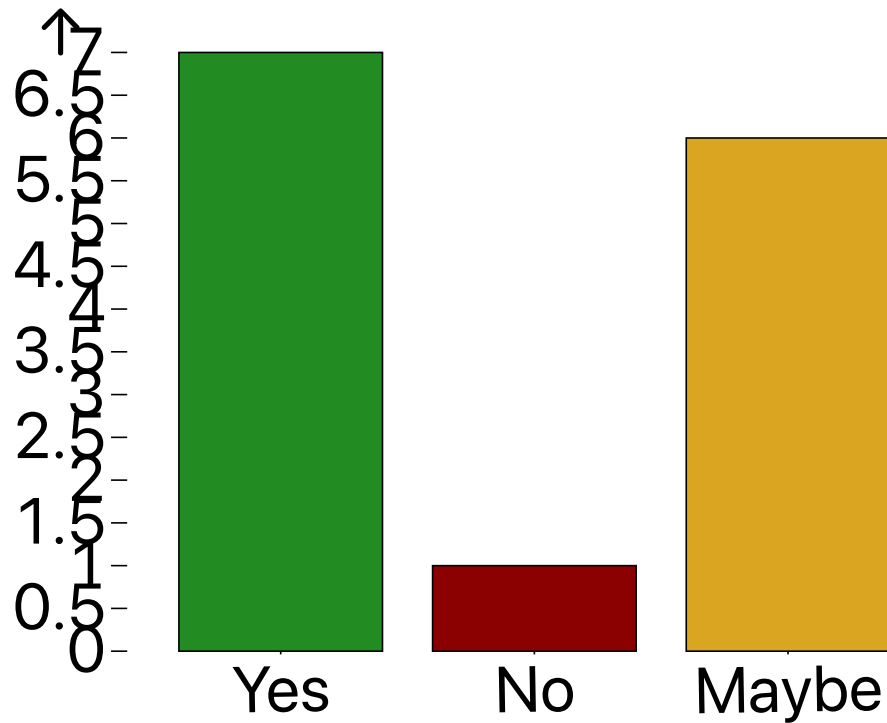


online movement activity more
individualised?

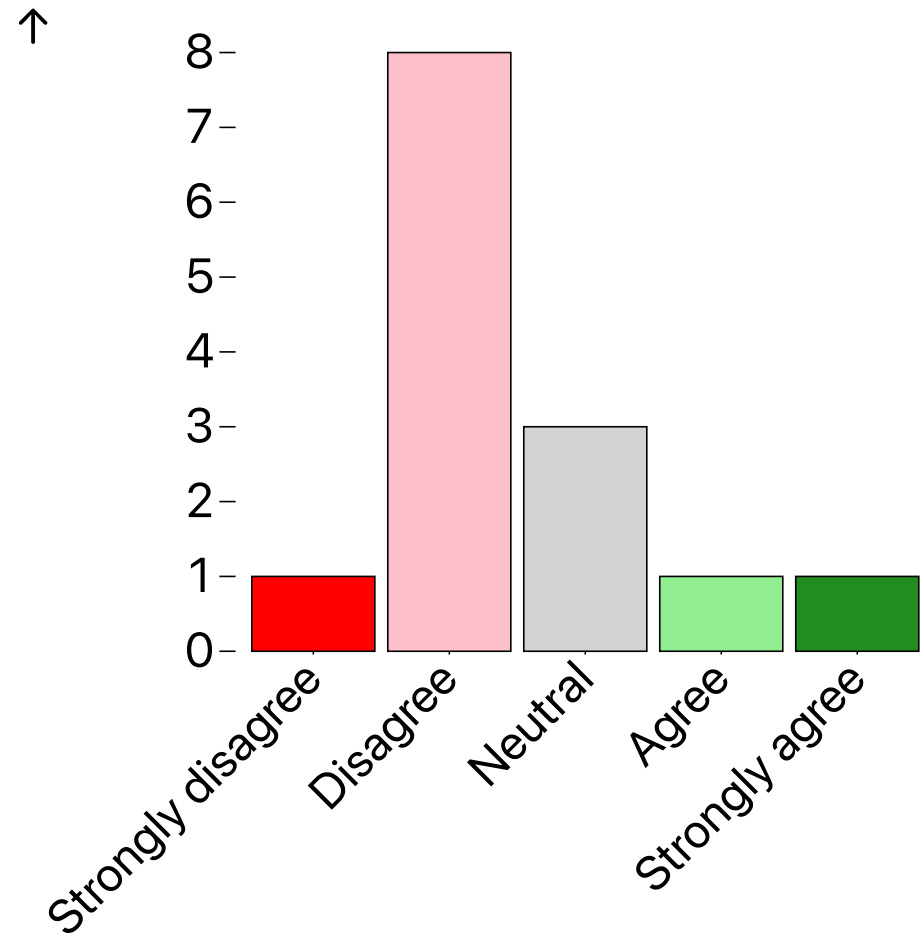


Poll results

platforms amplify movements of the marginalised?

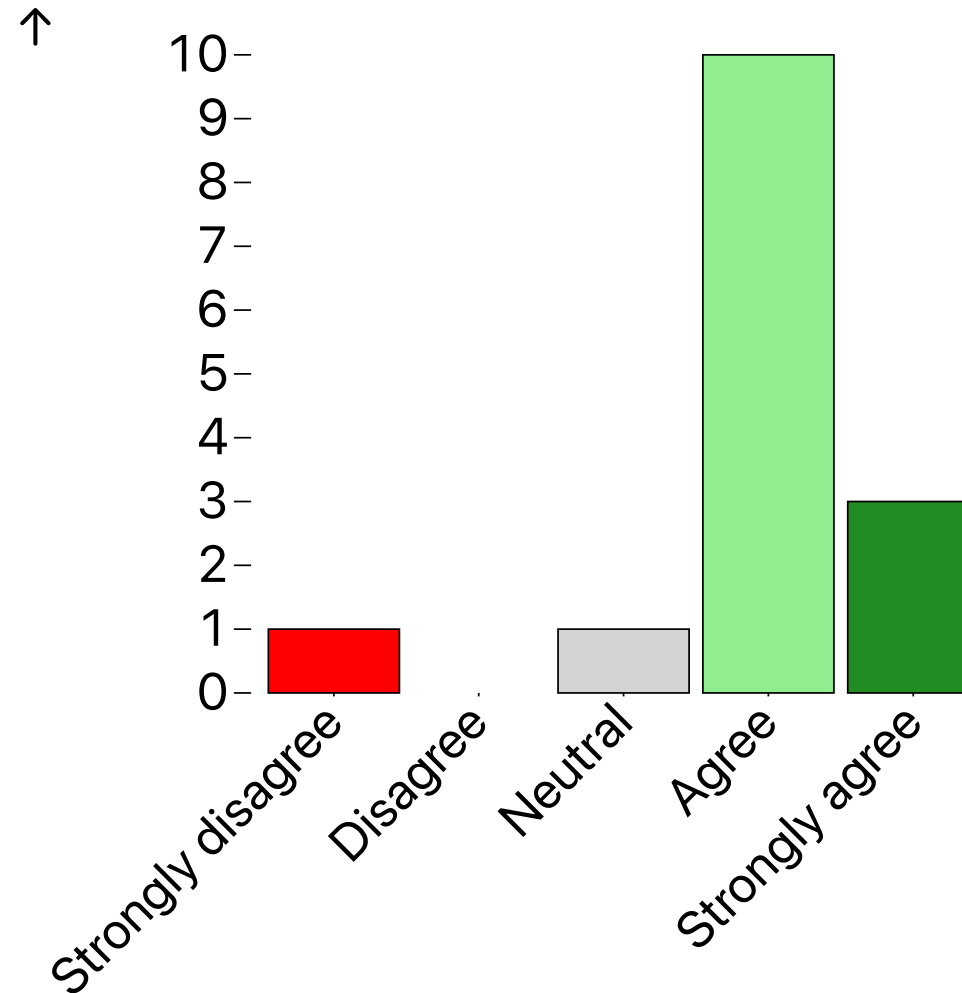


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Poll results

online movement activity often encourages a “slacktivism”



Poll results

Poll results

most important online tool for SMs?

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Array(13) ["TikTok", "Instagram", "instagram", "Social media",  
"tiktok", "A platform", "Social media ", "Social media in  
general ", "Instagram, TikTok,(Spreading Knowledge) YouTube  
(Deepening Knowledge)", "Instagram, maybe tiktok", "Gaining  
attention through Clips", "social media", "SNS(X)"]
```

Movements changed by the Internet

- Internet has changed both
 - how individuals participate, and
 - how movement organisations operate
- Examples:
 - Otpor, Slobodan Milosevic, and the Bulldozer revolution
 - Google bombing
- Democratising impact?
 - Hong Kong



Otpor, Milosevic, and the Bulldozer revolution



Google bombing

- manipulating a search engine algorithm to rank highly certain websites
- Examples:

Google bombing



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 - in 2006, Google searches for “failure” returned sites for George W. Bush’s biography

Google bombing



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 - in 2012, UK activists got search results for “EDL” to return, instead of *English Defence League*, pages for the *English Disco Lovers*
 - in 2018, search results for “idiot” returned images of Donald Trump



Diani (2000) - CMC's democratizing impact

the overall democratizing impact of CMC may be severely hampered by two types of resource constraints: while its contribution to networking among citizens' organizations is undeniable, its contribution to the **operations of social control agencies**, the military, governments and corporations is – at least quantitatively – much greater; and **access to CMC** is at least for the time being **heavily correlated to class and status**

What do you think? Is CMC a democratizing tool?

The case of Hong Kong...

Diani (2000) - CMC's democratizing impact

Online replacing offline activism

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Volk (2021) research design

explores how political actors in Germany performed control during the first wave of the COVID-19 pandemic, comparing the performances of control by two institutional actors and one counter-institutional grassroots actor

A *very* brief introduction to interpretive research



- **Interpretivism** - philosophical perspective that *reality and knowledge are socially constructed*
 - cf. (post-)positivist perspectives: there is an 'objective reality' that can be measured and tested
 - Galileo Galilei: '*Count what is countable, measure what is measurable and what is not measurable, make measurable.*'
 - has **epistemological consequences**: i.e., if reality is socially constructed, in what ways can we obtain knowledge about it?
 - ANSWER: techniques to identify and assess the **meanings that people attach to events, actions, etc.**
- **interpretivist** findings dependent on researcher's interpretation
 - problematic (according to some): difficulty of *replicability*, easy for '*bias*' to slant interpretation, difficult to *generalise*

Volk (2021) - PEGIDA 'virtueller Abendspaziergang'

27.04.2020 Dritter virtueller Abendspaziergang



Volk (2021) - findings (1)

Cases	Style			Intended audience	Transmission mode
	Habitus	Communication modes	Emotional tone	Intended audience	Transmission mode
Merkel	informer of the people	monological, unidirectional	Empathic, caring	National media audience	Conventional media
Kretschmer	Interlocutor of the people	Dialogical, multidirectional	Engaged, brave	Local immediate audience; regional and national media audience	New media; partially immediate
PEGIDA	Enlightened leader of the people	Monological and plurillogical, unidirectional	Enraged, mocking	Regional, national, and transnational media audience	New media

Volk (2021) - findings (1)

how (if at all) do you recall Merkel's televised address at the start of the pandemic? ([https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=4YS20YQbVE4&pp=ygUXbWVya2VsIGNvcn9uYSBhbnNwcmFjaGU%](https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=4YS20YQbVE4&pp=ygUXbWVya2VsIGNvcn9uYSBhbnNwcmFjaGU%3F))

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Volk (2021) - findings (2)

Styles of communication align with implicit and/or explicit understanding of democracy:

Cases	Floating meanings of 'democracy'		
	Dominant meaning	Hierarchical dynamics	Safeguarded by
Merkel	Openness of the decision-making procedures	Top-down	Governmental accountability and transparency
Kretschmer	Civil rights, especially freedom of speech	Bottom-up	Dialogue between elected representatives and citizens
PEGIDA	Civil rights, especially freedom of speech; Rule of law	Bottom-up	Citizens' activism and protest

Volk (2021) - key assertions

1. Political performances of control in Germany during the COVID-19 pandemic were characterised by constant appeals to the **idea(l) of democracy**.
2. Control is something that needs to be constantly (re-)articulated in political performances.
3. Performances are carefully staged and purposefully disseminated discursive events that aim to articulate political meaning.

Meta (Facebook, Instagram, Threads—3 billion users worldwide) ‘drastically reduces factcheckers and recommends more political content’

- Zuckerberg intended to “*dramatically reduce the amount of censorship*” (**framing contest**: ‘censorship’ vs. ‘content moderation’)
- Zuckerberg to “*work with President Trump to push back on governments around the world that are going after American companies and pushing to censor more*”. He cited Europe as a place with “*an ever-increasing number of laws institutionalising censorship and making it difficult to build anything innovative*”

Reconnecting online activism to (offline) impact



Zeynep Tufekci (UNC Chapel Hill): How online social movements translate to offline results

Two recent findings from research on online movement activity

- influencers on social media can have a massive impact on elections and other political events (e.g., Rezo anti-CDU video in 2019: Klüver (2024))
- deplatforming from mainstream social media platforms has a major impact on movement actors and activists (e.g., Rauchfleisch and Kaiser 2024)

Any questions, concerns, feedback for this class?

Anonymous feedback here: <https://forms.gle/AjHt6fcnwZxkSg4X8>

Alternatively, please send me an email: m.zeller@lmu.de

References

- Diani, Mario. 2000. "Social Movement Networks Virtual and Real." *Information, Communication & Society* 3 (3): 386–401. <https://doi.org/10.1080/13691180051033333>.
- Klüver, Heike. 2024. "Social Influencers and Election Outcomes." *Comparative Political Studies*, December, 00104140241306955. <https://doi.org/10.1177/00104140241306955>.
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- Volk, Sabine. 2021. "Political Performances of Control During COVID-19: Controlling and Contesting Democracy in Germany." *Frontiers in Political Science* 3 (June): 1–16. <https://doi.org/10.3389/fpos.2021.654069>.